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"Harm" is difficult to find:

An analysis of Kristie Dotson's framework of silencing through the lens of the Grecian Framework

Imagine you are in a heated argument with an amazing point, and you cannot wait to speak it out loud. Your turn is about to come, you get excited and stand up with your opinion, but when you speak it out loud you are met with confused faces. Nobody acknowledges it. They continue arguing while ignoring you. You feel claustrophobic and lost. That is how many people feel daily, feeling unworthy and discarded. You were silenced.

Needless to say, we need to prevent silencing as anyone can be negatively affected by it. However, we need a framework to define what is silencing before we act against it. One such framework is presented by Dr Kristie Dotson, philosopher specializing in epistemology and feminist philosophy, in her seminal paper "Tracking Epistemic Violence, Tracking Practices of Silencing". Dotson's definition of silencing is based on pernicious ignorance. According to her, ignorance simply arises from a gap in knowledge between two communicating parties. However, if this gap causes harm to one or both parties, we call it pernicious ignorance. In this case the ignorant is said to be behaving in an epistemically violent manner. Dotson argues that this pernicious ignorance leads to silencing (Dotson, pg. 238). It must be made clear that, pernicious ignorance is not the only factor that leads to silencing, but it is a necessary one. In this paper, I will focus on pernicious ignorance only.

While it may seem this framework is useful, I believe defining "harm" and classifying something as pernicious ignorance is a difficult task, making this framework limited. Another framework is provided by Dr Ishani Maitra — who specialises in language and feminist

philosophy — that is independent of pernicious ignorance. Instead, she focuses exclusively on communication breakdown between two parties. Therefore, in this paper, I will first explain Dotson's framework and then present Maitra's framework. Upon comparing both frameworks using examples, I will argue that Maitra's framework is better because it does not require subjective measures such as harm and pernicious ignorance as necessary conditions to define silencing like Dotson's. Subjective measures could differ from individual to individual and thus become difficult to define. Lastly, I will conclude with a potential objection that both frameworks are similar in effect and provide a rebuttal for it.

To understand Dotson's framework, let's say we have a speaker, speaking to an audience. Due to pernicious ignorance, the audience might think the speaker does not know what they are talking about. The audience would discredit the speaker and not listen to them, thus silencing the speaker. Dotson calls this, testimonial quieting (Dotson, pg. 242). On the other hand, if the speaker self-censor themselves or does not consider the audience worthy enough to be spoken to due to pernicious ignorance, the speaker has silenced themselves. This is called testimonial smothering (Dotson, pg. 244). In both cases pernicious ignorance has led to silencing.

Like Dotson, Maitra's framework is also based on communication between a speaker and an audience. However, since she believes that silencing prevents individuals from gaining benefits that only speech can provide (Maitra, pg. 333) (such as protests and criticism), her framework focuses exclusively on speech to define silencing. Hereafter, this framework will be called the Gricean framework (Maitra, pg. 325). Suppose a speaker says something to an audience. If (i) the audience produces a response *R*, (ii) the audience realizes that the speaker intended them to produce the response *R*, and (iii) this realization is enough for the audience to produce the correct response *R*, successful communication has taken place. However, if any of

the three conditions are not met, the framework concludes that the audience has silenced the speaker. This framework is independent of any pernicious ignorance.

With knowledge of both frameworks, I will examine an example from Patricia Hill Collins' book *Black Feminist Thought* through the lens of both frameworks. Collins say that black women are considered *"mammies, matriarchs, welfare mothers, and/or whores"* (Dotson, pg. 242). These stereotypes create negative stigma towards them. Clearly, this is not an accurate representation of black women, yet the stereotypes cause others to be ignorant towards their reality. If a black woman raises her voice towards societal issues such as financial inequity in the community, others will not consider her as a *"knower"* (Dotson, pg. 245) and not treat her seriously. Thus, her views would mean nothing, which is harmful towards her. Therefore, in Dotson's framework this ignorance was pernicious, and she has been silenced. More specifically, testimonial quieting has taken place. According to Maitra's framework, her audience might have realised that the black woman demands societal change (meeting rule (ii)). However, this realisation would not be enough for them to provide her the change given the stereotypes and stigma, hence they will fail to fulfil rule (i) and (iii). Thus, the woman has been silenced. Both frameworks can accurately predict the silencing here.

Superficially, both frameworks appear to work in a similar manner. The real difference appears when we consider an example where harm is difficult to define. Dotson gives an example of a three-year-old child not listening to its parents about the dangers of fire, and causing fire damage (Dotson, pg. 240). She further says that *"It is, to my mind, perfectly reasonable to say that a child is, at least, acting in an epistemically violent manner by not heeding the warning"* (Dotson, pg. 240) implying the child is testimonial-ly quieting its parents by being perniciously ignorant towards the dangers of fire. However, when I first read this example, it was not, to my mind, perfectly reasonable to infer that the child was being perniciously ignorant even though it was clear the child was silencing its parents. In fact, I

thought the child was behaving normally, like how you would expect it to behave. Here lies the problem: asserting something as "harm" is a subjective experience; it depends on the belief system of an individual. This subjectivity causes different people to have different meanings of harm, and thus defining pernicious ignorance becomes difficult. This also implies that different people will not agree whether something counts as silencing or not. For example, in this case, I am unable to find the pernicious ignorance but Dotson can, and if we use her framework, I cannot classify the child example as silencing. If we can't agree whether an event is of silencing, what hope do we have to prevent it? On the other hand, the Gricean framework does not suffer from this issue. It is based on objective rules, that are independent of whether we define something as harm. Consequently, it becomes useful where we face difficulty in finding the pernicious ignorance.

At this instance, some could object that the child's example is also a case of silencing according to Gricean Framework. The parents (speakers) warn the child (audience) to not play with fire, and they expect the child to stop playing with it. However, the child does not realise that they are expecting it to stop. For the child, fire is a toy. Therefore, the child does not produce the expected response and silences its parents. Even in the case where harm was initially difficult to define, both Maitra and Dotson's framework concluded that this example was of silencing. So, is there actually any real merit of Maitra's framework over Dotson if both can just end up defining silencing similarly?

While this sounds like a valid argument, it fails due to the subjectivity involved. As mentioned before, defining harm is subjective. This means for every case that the Gricean framework will define as silencing, there will always be someone who could find pernicious ignorance and use Dotson's framework to do the same. However, at the same time, someone else will disagree that the harm was not significant enough to be considered pernicious. In my opinion, all cases of silencing, regardless of the initial degree of harm, should be defined as

silencing. As Maitra states, *"…not every silenced speaker is wrong in the same way, or to the same extent, as a result of being silenced."* (Maitra, pg. 333) which implies all cases of silencing are harmful[1] but the degree of harm could be different. Not calling something silencing just because it is 'less harmful' according to some arbitrary individual, is unfair to the silenced individual. Therefore, employing Maitra's framework is better than Dotson's framework as it is fair and easier to employ.

In conclusion, I argued in this paper that the definition of pernicious ignorance is broad and ambiguous, and therefore we should instead use the Grecian framework to define when silencing takes place. After analysing multiple examples, I believe it is not a stretch to assert that it's easier and fairer to define silencing through Maitra's framework than Dotson's framework because it is objective. We can treat Dotson's framework as a special and rare case of Maitra's framework, where someone always finds pernicious ignorance. Expanding on, we have discussed failed communications through silencing, but how to prevent this? Could certain education systems inculcate values and eradicate stigmas such that people respect others and not silence them? Or is it beyond education and another systemic change is required?

References

[1] Dotson, Kristie. "Tracking Epistemic Violence, Tracking Practices of Silencing." *Hypatia*, Vol. 26, No. 2, 2011, pp. 236-257.

[2] Maitra, Ishani. "Silencing Speech." *Canadian Journal of Philosophy*, Vol. 39, No. 2, 2009, pp. 309-338.

[1] In her paper, Dotson actually engages with this argument and opposes it. She draws a distinction between *"an instance of silencing"* and *"a practice of silencing"*. Through this, she argues that practices of silencing are repetitive and thus, more concerning. However, I believe instances of silencing could also repeat; we just do not know if they will. Therefore, they are equally concerning.